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The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, mostly sunny, warmer, high 67. **Tonight,** clear early, partly cloudy later, low 55. **Tomorrow,** turning mostly sunny, breezy and warm, high 71. Weather map is on Page B12.

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Another Crash Plunges Spain In Grief Again

Second Fatal Accident on Same Rail Line

This article is by ***Jason Horowitz****,* ***José Bautista*** *and* ***Carlos Barragán****.*

MADRID — Traveling home on a high-speed train from Madrid to Seville in Spain, Fernando Seco was annoyed when congestion caused the train to stop about a half-hour after its 8 a.m. departure Wednesday. Not long after, it restarted, picked up speed and slammed into another train stopped on the tracks.

Mr. Seco, 62, and other panicked passengers climbed out of their carriage at the back of the train and into a field in central Spain. They saw the derailed carriages of the train they had barreled into in an embankment farther ahead. A rail beam, he said, had "pierced right through a carriage from bottom to top, like carving meat."

He and others rushed to those carriages and found the dead and injured, those "trapped in a twisted tangle of metal and wreckage."

The scene was eerily quiet because people were either dead or so hurt they couldn't speak. He said survivors used parts of the destroyed train as makeshift stretchers to extract the injured from the wreckage. That's when the screaming started. Doctors among the passengers treated people in what became a field hospital among almond groves.

At least 68 people died in the crash. More than 50 others were injured, some critically.

Spain is living through a recurring nightmare. For the second time in less than a year, a high-speed crash between the same two train operators on the same

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JAVIER SORIANO/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE — GETTY IMAGES

A train crash between a high-speed train and a stationary train south of Madrid left at least 68 dead and dozens hurt on Wednesday.

Inside the Democrats' Effort to Stack the Alaska Midterm Ballot

Plan to Coax Potential Spoilers Into Race for Senate Seat

By KELLEN BROWNING

In the summer of 2025, a staffer for Mary Peltola, the Alaska Democrat who was eyeing a run for Senate, received unusual instructions from top campaign aides: Find as many people named Dan Sullivan in Alaska as you can.

The staffer complied, combing through voter records to produce a list of Dan Sullivans from across the state.

This was no random request. Dan S. Sullivan is the name of the state's Republican senator. And if the Peltola campaign or its allies could track down and persuade another Dan Sullivan to run for Senate, the confusion could cost the senator crucial votes on the state's unusual, four-person ballot.

The plan worked. This spring, a retired teacher from a tiny fishing village along the Alaska Panhandle, reachable only by air and sea, announced his candidacy for Senate. His name was Dan J. Sullivan.

The Peltola campaign has repeatedly denied any involvement in his candidacy. But The Times has found, based on interviews and text messages, along with documents prepared for a potential lawsuit against the campaign, that not only did Ms. Peltola's team work with people trying to recruit Mr. Sullivan to run for Senate, but that the effort was much broader. The group worked to coax other would-be spoilers into the race, to dilute the incumbent's support and help catapult the Democrat to victory.

The endeavor, which was internally called the ballot composition

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ISRAEL IN LIMBO AS VOTING YIELDS NO CLEAR VICTOR

EARLY NETANYAHU LEAD

Arab Support Could Be Pivotal in Talks on a Possible Coalition

This article is by ***Isabel Kershner****,* ***Johnatan Reiss****,* ***Aaron Boxerman****,* ***Qasim Nauman*** *and* ***Michael Levenson****.*

JERUSALEM — Israeli political leaders braced on Wednesday for days or weeks of negotiations over the shape of the next government after election results showed no clear winner between Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's right-wing coalition and a diverse bloc of opposition parties.

About 80 percent of the votes had been counted as of Wednesday afternoon local time in an election that had the highest voter turnout in Israel since 1999. Those votes, combined with exit polls, indicated that Mr. Netanyahu's alliance will have more seats than the opposition bloc led by Gadi Eisenkot, a former Israeli military chief of staff, but neither will have the 61 seats needed to secure a majority in the Knesset, Israel's Parliament.

That means either side would need to find support from outside its bloc to form a government and select a prime minister. Two Arab parties were projected to win a total of about 18 seats — a remarkable show of strength that could make them Mr. Eisenkot's only path to toppling Mr. Netanyahu.

Israel's president, Isaac Herzog, said he would not begin consulting party leaders about forming a government until next week, when he expects to receive the full, official vote count. As head of state, Mr. Herzog will pick whoever he thinks has the best shot at assembling a majority in the Knesset.

The wrangling among parties can be drawn out and bruising. If the first candidate fails to gain support, Mr. Herzog can ask up two others. If they also fail, new elections would be held.

"We must do everything we can, certainly after yesterday, to avoid another round of elections," Mr. Herzog said on Wednesday.

The election on Tuesday was Israel's first since the Hamas-led attack on Oct. 7, 2023, and was widely seen as a referendum on Mr. Netanyahu and the coalition of hard-line nationalists and ultra-Orthodox Jews that he formed in 2022, the most far-right in Israeli history.

The early results, though subject to change, indicated that Mr. Netanyahu, a canny survivor over more than three decades in Israeli politics, had emerged with a good chance of clinging to power even though he fell short of an outright victory.

His alliance could drop from 68 seats to roughly 54 and lose its

Continued on Page A7

DOLORES HUERTA, 1930-2026

Labor Leader of Farm Workers Who Earned Folk-Hero Status

By ROBERT D. McFADDEN

Dolores Huerta, who with Cesar Chavez founded what became the United Farm Workers and led strikes and boycotts in the 1960s and '70s that unionized many California table-grape growers, changing laws and the lives of thousands of migrant laborers, died on Wednesday at her home in Bakersfield, Calif. She was 96.



SEPTEMBER DAWN BOTTOMS FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

The cause of death was cancer, Erik Olvera, a spokesman for her family, said.

Ms. Huerta, who became a kind of Mexican American folk hero, depicted in murals and ballads, was the union's vice president for nearly four decades and, until Mr. Chavez's death in 1993, his second-in-command. He was the charismatic — and, it was later revealed, abusive — leader; she, the skilled organizer who coordinated walkouts and boycotts under a black Aztec eagle banner and negotiated pathbreaking contracts

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RICARDO ARDUENGO/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE — GETTY IMAGES

Defeated Brazilian Candidate Lands in U.S.
Flávio Bolsonaro, with a canceled passport, arrived in Miami with his family Wednesday. Page A8.

C.T.E. in Football May Be Broader Than Feared

Study Links Disease to 3 in 4 Ex-N.F.L. Players

By CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON and JOHN BRANCH

This summer, a scientific study sent reverberations through the football world, making headlines and deeply worrying players and families.

At least 25 percent of retired N.F.L. players who died over a recent six-year period, the study found, had C.T.E., or chronic traumatic encephalopathy, the neurodegenerative brain disease associated with repeated hits to the head.

But most of the other 75 percent of deceased players were never tested. That left a complex, high-stakes question — the actual prevalence of C.T.E. among deceased ex-players — open for analysis.

Now, the same research team has deployed statistical techniques to home in on a more precise number. In a new study published Wednesday, they estimate that three out of four former N.F.L. players who died between 2008 and 2023 most likely had C.T.E. in their brains at death.

By contrast, the same re-

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A.I. Health Advice and a Devastating Outcome

Using Chatbot's Plan to Taper Epilepsy Drug

By TEDDY ROSENBLUTH

Qun Wan was in the middle of a heated call with his daughter, Bowen Wan, when the phone suddenly went silent.

The conversation, in early February, had started like most of their regular check-ins, a ritual that had kept them connected after Bowen moved from their small village in China to the United States.

But the mood soured when she admitted she had been cutting back on a seizure medication that kept her severe epilepsy under control. She told him she had been slicing her tablets into pieces with a pill cutter, allowing her to reduce her dose by one-fourth, Qun recalled.

Listen to your doctor, he pleaded. Bowen, 31, shot back that doctors didn't care how the drug's side effects affected her. She felt that the drug made her speaking stilted and her thinking slow.

Then, abruptly, she stopped talking. Thirty seconds passed, then a minute, then two. It was longer than seizures she'd had be-

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INTERNATIONAL A4-8

Another Carrot for Russia?
Dropping sanctions on Vladimir Putin's multibillion-dollar "slush fund" would be the latest U.S. concession "to help end" the Ukraine war. PAGE A5

NATIONAL A9-17

Trump Eases Methane Limits
Rules passed by the Biden administration that aimed to reduce the release of a potent climate-warming gas from oil wells are being weakened. PAGE A10

BUSINESS B1-6

Legal Firm May Soon Dissolve
Weil Gotshal & Manges has been rocked by an exodus of top lawyers, a failed succession plan and a scuttled deal to merge with a rival firm. PAGE B1

THURSDAY STYLES D1-6

His Not-So-Haunted House
A writer who was once a neighbor to R.L. Stine, the author of the "Goosebumps" series, finally summons up the nerve to visit his house. PAGE D6

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Jennifer M. Harris PAGE A18

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